

Agentic commerce

What it is, who is building it, what is actually live today, and where a US cards business is exposed. Best current thinking from the US card industry and from the four markets solving this differently.

+393%

Growth in AI-referred traffic to US retail sites, year over year, Q1 2026

~1.5%

Share of US e-commerce transacted on AI platforms today — the volume has not arrived yet

4

National models for who vouches for an agent: a contract, a regulation, a registry, a platform

THE THESIS IN ONE LINE



The click disappears and is replaced by a signed chain of mandates. Everything contested in this market — liability, ranking, provisioning, disputes — hangs off who issues, verifies and stores those three signatures.

WHAT THIS COVERS

- 02-04 **The architecture**
How an agent-mediated purchase is assembled, and where the money moves
- 05 **The transaction**
One purchase drawn end to end, with the open liability questions marked
- 06-07 **Builders and implementations**
Who is driving it, and the three models actually running today
- 08-09 **Global and competitive view**
Four national models; where the contested ground sits
- 10 **Implications**
What a US cards business should do, and what to watch

All figures dated and sourced on each slide. Distinguish measured telemetry from modelled forecasts.

Agent-referred demand is still small in absolute terms — but it now converts better than the traffic it replaces.

A year ago the agentic channel underperformed on every commercial metric. It has crossed over. The volume is not yet material; the direction and the quality of the traffic are.

+393% Growth in AI-referred traffic to US retail sites Year over year, Q1 2026. March alone up 269%.	+42% Conversion advantage of AI-referred visitors March 2026, versus other traffic. In March 2025 the same traffic converted 38% worse.	~1.5% Share of US e-commerce transacted on AI platforms ≈ \$20.6B in 2026, roughly 4× the 2025 level.	\$190B US agentic commerce by 2030, base case ≈10% of US e-commerce. Bull case \$385B (~20%).	\$3–5T Global agentic commerce revenue by 2030 Modelled, not measured. Treat as a range, not a plan.
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FOUR EVIDENCE CLASSES

Coverage prints platform telemetry, vendor program data, consumer surveys and analyst forecasts side by side as if they were one number. **They are not.**

ADOPTION IS FRONT-LOADED

Roughly **62%** of AI commerce usage sits at product comparison, **23%** at checkout, **19%** post-purchase. Discovery is where behaviour has actually changed.

MEASUREMENT IS BROKEN

An estimated **70%** of AI referrals are invisible in standard analytics, so most retailers undercount the channel 3–4×. Assume our own reads are low.

THE PLANNING IMPLICATION

Plan against the **measured** numbers — traffic, conversion, revenue per visit. Budget against the forecast **range**, and revisit after holiday 2026.

What this means for us: the channel is not yet material to card volume, but it is already material to acquisition and to how our partners get found. The decision that matters this year is **provisioning** — not forecasting.

Sources: Adobe Analytics, Q1 2026 report (16 Apr 2026) — traffic growth, conversion, revenue per visit; eMarketer via Digital Applied (Aug 2026) — US AI-platform retail e-commerce ≈\$20.6B; Morgan Stanley AlphaWise (Nov 2025) — \$190B base / \$385B bull; McKinsey and Salesforce + Publicis Sapient (May 2026) — \$3–5T global by 2030; global AI-commerce adoption report (Aug 2026) — journey-stage usage split; ToolGlance, State of AI in Ecommerce & Retail 2026 — analytics undercounting.

Agentic commerce is a five-layer stack — the customer relationship forms at the top, and the card sits at the bottom.

These layers are not rival standards; a single purchase can traverse all of them. The strategic question is never "which protocol" — it is which layer you can defend.

05	SURFACE	Where the intent forms and the goal is stated. ChatGPT · Gemini & AI Mode · Copilot · Alipay · WeChat	Owns the customer's first question — and therefore the consideration set.
04	DISCOVERY	Machine-readable catalogue, price and inventory. UCP manifests (/ .well-known/ucp) · MCP endpoints · product feeds	Owns whether you are visible at all . Unstructured data is invisible data.
03	CHECKOUT	Cart, order and fulfilment semantics. UCP checkout sessions · ACP in-surface purchase	Owns merchant of record and the order data — the contested seam.
02	TRUST	Proof that a human authorised this agent for this purchase . AP2 mandates (W3C Verifiable Credentials) · Mastercard Verifiable Intent · Visa Trusted Agent Protocol · Web Bot Auth · agentic tokens	Owns liability and dispute attribution . The layer cards can actually win.
01	MONEY	The rail that clears and settles the value. Card networks · account-to-account and UPI · stablecoin / x402 at machine ticket sizes	Owns the economics — and is the layer most easily substituted.

**GOVERNANCE PLANE
(CUTS EVERY LAYER)**

Not a sixth layer. Identity, consent and recourse have to hold at every step or the whole chain is unenforceable.

- Agent identity & registration
- Scoped spending limits
- Signed consent record
- Immutable audit log
- Dispute & reversal path
- Model-risk oversight

Sources: Google/Shopify Universal Commerce Protocol (NRF, Jan 2026); OpenAI + Stripe Agentic Commerce Protocol (29 Sep 2025); Google Agent Payments Protocol (AP2), contributed to FIDO Alliance 28 Apr 2026; Anthropic Model Context Protocol (Nov 2024); Visa Trusted Agent Protocol (Oct 2025, with Cloudflare and Akamai); Mastercard Agent Pay / Agentic Tokens; IMF Note 2026/004, "How Agentic AI Will Reshape Payments" (Apr 2026); Coinbase x402 (May 2025). Protocol layering per Linux Foundation governance summary, Apr 2026.

Four value pools are repricing at once — and three of them sit above the card.

The rails are not under threat. The toll is. Card economics rest partly on a behaviour an agent does not reproduce: the customer who does not shop around and the default that never gets re-examined.

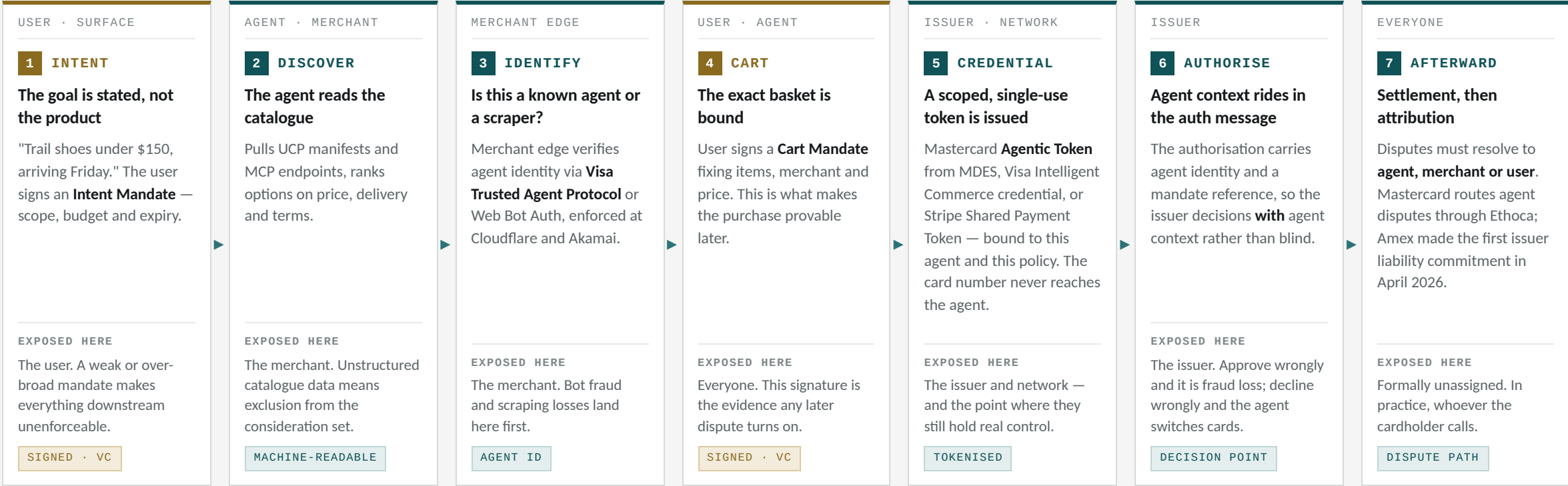
Discovery rent REPRICING WAS Paid search, SEO, retail media — bought attention. BECOMES Agent ranking and structured-feed quality. "Generative engine optimisation." WHO CAPTURES IT Surfaces that rank, and merchants with clean structured data. CARDS' STAKE Indirect but real — it determines traffic to co-brand and retail-services partners.	Checkout control CONTESTED WAS The merchant's own site and its checkout. BECOMES Split. UCP keeps the merchant as merchant of record; in-surface ACP checkout does not. WHO CAPTURES IT Undecided — platforms and merchants are actively fighting over it. CARDS' STAKE Order data, dispute rights and rewards attachment all follow merchant of record.	Trust & authorisation NEW POOL WAS Implicit and unpriced — CVV, 3-D Secure, strong customer authentication. BECOMES An explicit, priced service: agent registration, scoped mandates, verifiable intent, dispute attribution. WHO CAPTURES IT Networks, issuers and PSPs — whoever the merchant and the regulator will believe. CARDS' STAKE The defensible one. Issuers already hold the liability, the disputes machinery and the regulator relationship.	Funding-source choice EXISTENTIAL WAS Top of wallet — habit, rewards, the card you reach for. BECOMES Top of mandate — whichever credential is already provisioned into the agent's permission set. WHO CAPTURES IT Whoever gets provisioned into the agent first, and stays there. CARDS' STAKE If the card is not provisioned before the agent shops, it is not in the consideration set at all.
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An agent has no top-of-wallet position to protect and no attachment to a brand or a piece of metal. It will not pay close to 2% if a cheaper rail clears the same purchase to the same merchant. THE PAYPERS, MAY 2026 — US AVERAGE INTERCHANGE ≈1.81%	"The differentiator won't be 'AI' — it will be governance: identity, consent, limits." JPMORGAN PAYMENTS, ON ITS MIRAKL AGENTIC-COMMERCE AGREEMENT, 2026
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Sources: The Paypers, "Agentic commerce does not threaten the rails, it threatens the toll" (19 May 2026) — interchange range and agent-inertia argument; JPMorgan Payments / Mirakl Nexus agreement (Mar 2026); Kansas City Fed per-transaction credit cost estimates (\$0.50-\$0.80); Google/Shopify UCP merchant-of-record design; OpenAI + Stripe ACP; Accenture retail commentary on the shift from search to generative engine optimisation (2026).

Human authorisation moves upstream — and every step downstream has to prove it happened.

One purchase, end to end. The consumer signs once, early, at the goal; the rest of the chain carries cryptographic evidence of that consent forward to the merchant, the network and the issuer.



Still unresolved — and this is where the strategy actually lives. Chargeback liability for agent-initiated purchases has not been formally assigned by the networks. Regulation E treatment of an agent's error is untested. In the EU, strong customer authentication assumes a human payer, and an AI agent is not a "payer" under current definitions. Whoever settles these three questions sets the commercial terms for everyone else.

Sources: Google AP2 specification — Intent, Cart and Payment mandates as W3C Verifiable Credentials; Visa Trusted Agent Protocol (Oct 2025, Cloudflare/Akamai) and Web Bot Auth; Mastercard Agent Pay — Agentic Tokens issued from MDES, disputes via Ethoca; Visa Intelligent Commerce; Stripe Shared Payment Tokens, extended Mar 2026 to Visa Intelligent Commerce, Mastercard Agent Pay, Affirm and Klarna; American Express ACE Developer Kit and Agent Purchase Protection (14 Apr 2026); Chargeflow (Jul 2026) and Osborne Clarke (Mar 2026) on unassigned liability and SCA.

Six kinds of player are building this — and only two of them are card companies.

Each group is trying to own a different layer of the stack. Read this as a map of who has an incentive to make our layer commoditised.

AI surfaces

LAYER 05

Trying to own: the moment intent forms

OpenAI (~50M shopping queries a day) · **Google** (Gemini, AI Mode, Search) · **Microsoft** (Copilot Checkout with PayPal) · **Anthropic** · **Perplexity** (Comet — enjoined from Amazon purchasing, Mar 2026)

Commerce platforms

LAYERS 04-03

Trying to own: the catalogue and the order

Shopify (UCP co-author; self-serve agent registration from 17 Jun 2026) · **Amazon** (Rufus — a deliberately closed loop) · **Walmart**, **Target**, **Instacart** (retailer apps inside ChatGPT) · **Wayfair**, **Etsy**, **Salesforce**, **commercetools**

Card networks

LAYERS 02-01

Trying to own: the trust layer and the rules

Visa — Intelligent Commerce, Trusted Agent Protocol, AI dispute programme · **Mastercard** — Agent Pay, Agentic Tokens, Verifiable Intent, Ethoca disputes · **American Express** — ACE Developer Kit, Agent Purchase Protection

Enablers & processors

ALL LAYERS

Trying to own: the integration surface for everyone else

Stripe (Shared Payment Tokens; ACP co-author) · **PayPal** (430M+ accounts; ACP server bringing SMBs into ChatGPT) · **Adyen**, **Worldline**, **Fiserv** · **FIS** (issuer agentic offering, Q1 2026) · **Cloudflare**, **Akamai** (the agent edge)

Issuers & banks

LAYERS 02-01

Trying to own: the funding source and the liability

Citi and **US Bank** — first live on Agent Pay, Sep 2025 · **JPMorgan** — merchant-side scale, deliberately slow on the consumer side · **Amex** — first issuer liability commitment · **Synchrony** — OpenAI partnership, Aug 2026 · **Capital One**, **Santander**, **ING**

Standards bodies

NEUTRALITY

Trying to own: the credibility that makes it investable

Linux Foundation — MCP, A2A, AP2 and UCP governance as of Apr 2026 · **FIDO Alliance** — took AP2 and Mastercard's Verifiable Intent in Apr 2026 · **W3C** — the Verifiable Credentials the mandates are built on

The most consequential governance event so far. On 28 April 2026 Google contributed AP2 to the FIDO Alliance alongside Mastercard's Verifiable Intent framework, and FIDO began work on interoperable agent-authentication standards. The trust layer moved out of a single vendor's hands and into the body that already owns passkeys — which is a reason to build to the standard rather than to any one company's implementation.

Sources: FIDO Alliance / Google AP2 contribution and Mastercard Verifiable Intent (28 Apr 2026); Linux Foundation governance of MCP, A2A, AP2 and UCP (Apr 2026); Shopify Spring '26 Edition self-serve agent registration (17 Jun 2026); Mastercard Agent Pay — Citi and US Bank first (Sep 2025), all US cardholders (Nov 2025); American Express ACE (14 Apr 2026); Synchrony-OpenAI partnership (Aug 2026); JPMorgan Payments / Mirakl (Mar 2026); FIS issuer agentic offering (Q1 2026); PayPal ACP server and account base; US federal preliminary injunction re Perplexity Comet and Amazon (Mar 2026); OpenAI shopping-query volume.

Three models are running today — and one high-profile retreat shows exactly where the friction sits.

The gap between announcement and adoption is the single most useful thing to understand about this market right now.

A • In-surface checkout

ACP — OPENAI + STRIPE

- ▶ User asks inside the assistant
- ▶ Agent presents products in-chat
- ▶ Stripe Shared Payment Token issued
- ▶ Merchant charges; assistant confirms

PRODUCT WITHDRAWN · PROTOCOL SURVIVES

Instant Checkout launched Sep 2025 with Shopify, Etsy and Walmart, and was wound down in **March 2026** after roughly five months with near-zero sales. ChatGPT pivoted to **retailer apps** — Walmart, Target, Instacart — where the brand remains merchant of record.

Read: consumers will research in the assistant. They have not yet been willing to complete purchase there.

B • Protocol-based commerce

UCP — GOOGLE + SHOPIFY

- ▶ Merchant publishes a UCP manifest
- ▶ Agent discovers and builds the cart
- ▶ AP2 mandate supplies consent proof
- ▶ Checkout completes in merchant control

LIVE AND EXPANDING

Announced at **NRF, Jan 2026**. **Universal Cart** extended it across Search, Gemini, YouTube and Gmail at I/O in **May 2026**. Launch partners include Wayfair, Revolut, Salesforce and commercetools; Shopify made registration self-serve in **June 2026**.

Read: the merchant keeps merchant of record. That is why enterprise retailers prefer it — and why it is winning.

C • Network and issuer rails

AGENT PAY · INTELLIGENT COMMERCE

- ▶ Cardholder enables an agent
- ▶ Scoped agentic token provisioned
- ▶ Agent transacts within policy
- ▶ Issuer authorises with agent context

LIVE AT SCALE

Mastercard Agent Pay: announced Apr 2025; **Citi and US Bank first live Sep 2025**; extended to all US cardholders Nov 2025; global rollout through 2026. **Visa**: live European agentic transactions with 30+ issuers from 2 Jul 2026.

Europe's first end-to-end production agentic payment was **Worldline + ING + Mastercard**, June 2026, across the Netherlands and Belgium.

The bottom line: discovery works, the rails are built and ahead of demand, and checkout inside the assistant does not yet convert. The near-term contest is not for the transaction — it is for the **provisioning decision** that happens before the agent ever shops.

Sources: OpenAI Instant Checkout launch (29 Sep 2025) and wind-down (Mar 2026), per Digital Applied and CruxDigits protocol reviews (Jun-Aug 2026); ChatGPT retailer apps with Walmart, Target and Instacart; Google/Shopify UCP announced NRF Jan 2026, Universal Cart at Google I/O 19 May 2026, Shopify self-serve registration 17 Jun 2026; Mastercard Agent Pay timeline (Apr 2025 announcement; Citi and US Bank Sep 2025; all US cardholders Nov 2025); Visa live European agentic transactions with 30+ issuers (2 Jul 2026); Worldline + ING + Mastercard first European production agentic payment (Jun 2026).

Four markets are answering the same question — who vouches for the agent? — with four different institutions.

This is the most useful comparison available. The technology is converging; the trust anchor is not, and the trust anchor is what determines who captures the value.

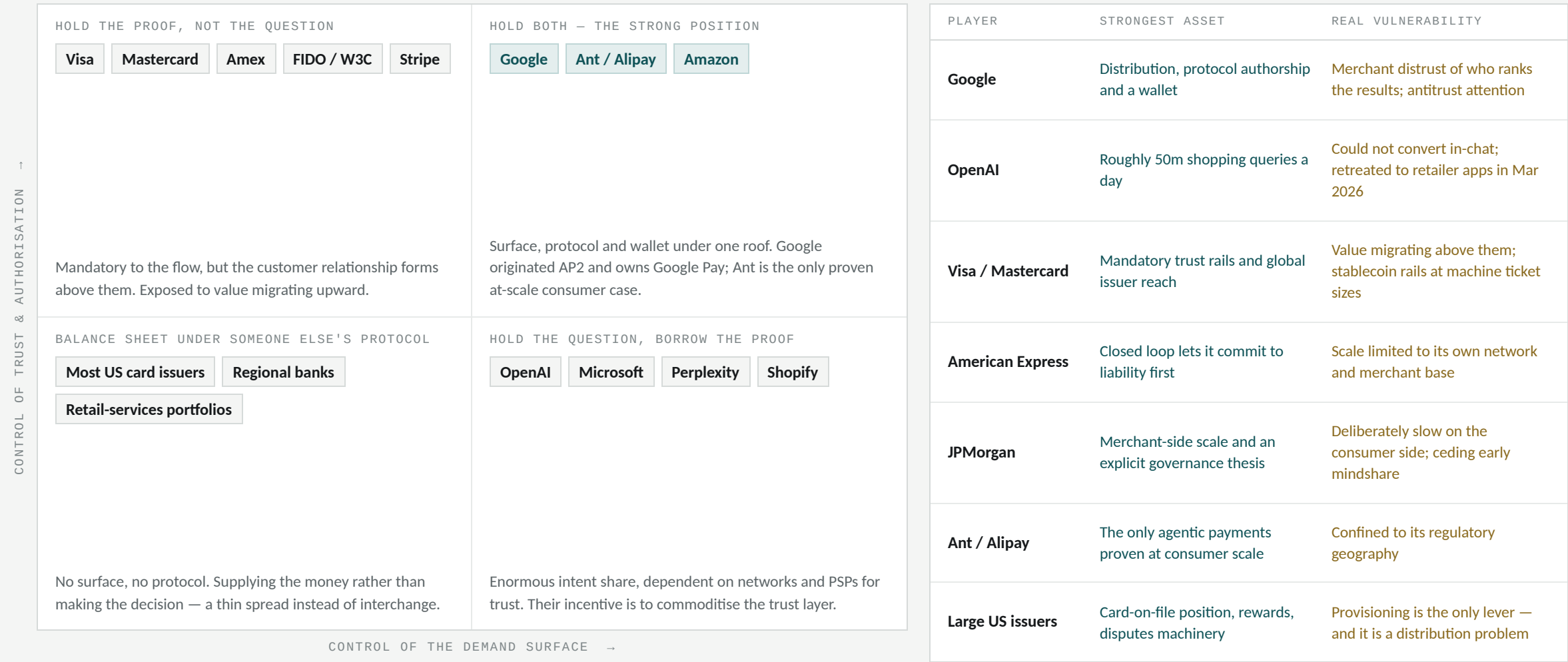
United States NETWORK - LED Private protocols competing in the open. Card rails carry the transaction; the networks supply agent identity, tokenisation and dispute routing. Coordination happens through competition plus FIDO, not through a regulator. Fastest to market, least settled on liability. Reg E treatment of agent error is untested and chargeback liability is not formally assigned. TRUST ANCHOR A commercial contract — network rules and issuer commitments.	Europe REGULATION - LED PSD2 and strong customer authentication govern today and assume a human payer — an AI agent is not a "payer" under current definitions. PSD3 / PSR remains in trilogue with no explicit agent provisions; implementation 2026–28. EU AI Act transparency obligations apply from Aug 2026. eIDAS 2.0 and the EUDI Wallet are the likely benchmark for non-repudiation on high-value approvals. TRUST ANCHOR A regulation — and a state-issued digital identity.	India PUBLIC INFRASTRUCTURE - LED NPCI is building a Unified Agent Protocol on UPI to register, verify and authorise agents — extending the existing UPI Circle delegated-payments model. NPCI validates the agent and keeps the log; by design it does not see what was bought. RBI approval is required before launch. Scale context: 22.71bn UPI transactions in June 2026 (₹28.92 trillion), 63.5% person-to-merchant. TRUST ANCHOR A national registry — the first of its kind anywhere.	China SUPER - APP - LED The only market with proven consumer agentic payments at scale. Alipay AI Pay passed 100m active users in Feb 2026 and processed 120m agent transactions in a single week. AI Wallet and Token Pay launched 26 May 2026; Alipay+ Agentic Mobile Protocol extends the model to partner wallets across Asia. Ant built a mandatory human-confirmation gate on any movement of funds. Tencent is embedding payment inside agent products rather than retrofitting WeChat Pay. TRUST ANCHOR The platform itself — closed loop, no external protocol needed.
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US	EUROPE	INDIA	CHINA	Whoever holds the agent registry holds the leverage. In the US, that is still open.
A contract	A regulation	A registry	A platform	

Sources: Osborne Clarke, "Agentic payments: a new challenge for Europe's payments ecosystem" (Mar 2026); European Business Magazine on EU liability overlap (Feb 2026); Reply, "Agentic checkout beyond the hype" — PSD3/PSR, eIDAS 2.0 and EUDI Wallet; EU AI Act transparency obligations from Aug 2026; Business Standard and Outlook Business on NPCI's Unified Agent Protocol (8–9 Jul 2026), UPI June 2026 volumes; Bloomberg via PYMNTS and IndexBox on Alipay's agent interface (15 Jun 2026); Ant Group AI Wallet and Token Pay (26 May 2026); China Biz Insider on Ant's human-confirmation gate and Tencent's approach (Jun 2026); Alipay+ Agentic Mobile Protocol (Ant International).

The contested ground is the mandate layer — not the surface, and not the rail.

Surfaces are consolidated. Rails are built. What no one yet owns is the durable, portable record of who authorised what.



Sources: Positioning synthesised from company disclosures cited on slides 06-08. Interchange and disintermediation argument per The Paypers (May 2026); stablecoin substitution at micro-ticket per Coinbase x402 and Kansas City Fed per-transaction cost estimates; Juniper Research (Apr 2026) identifying trust – not technical capability – as the leading barrier to agentic commerce deployment; Strive on the shift from top of wallet to agent-selected card-on-file (17 Jul 2026).

For a US cards business, three positions are durable: provisioning, trust services, and the partner side.

Ordered by how quickly the window closes. The first is a distribution problem we already know how to solve; the second is a product we are uniquely credentialled to sell.

1 Get provisioned before the agent shops

Top of wallet becomes **top of mandate**. A card that is not already in the agent's permission set is not in the consideration set. This is distribution, not product — and it is the one that compounds.

2 Sell trust, not just credit

Agent registration, scoped limits, verifiable intent and dispute attribution are a **product**, and issuers already hold the liability, the disputes machinery and the regulator relationship. Amex has shipped the clearest precedent.

3 Make rewards machine-readable

A ranking agent cannot value an offer it cannot parse. Rewards, merchant-funded offers and financing terms need to be exposed as **structured data** or they are simply absent at the moment of choice.

4 Work the merchant and partner side

Co-brand and retail-services partners are the ones adopting UCP. Their agent-readiness is **our portfolio economics**, and convening that conversation is something an issuer is well placed to do.

WHAT TO WATCH

- **FIDO Alliance** interoperable agent-authentication standards, following the AP2 and Verifiable Intent contributions of 28 Apr 2026
- **PSD3 / PSR trilogue** — whether delegated initiation and technical-service-provider liability get named explicitly
- **RBI decision** on NPCI's Unified Agent Protocol — the first national agent registry, and a template others will copy
- **First formal chargeback rules** for agent-initiated disputes; whether Amex's liability commitment forces the networks to follow
- **Holiday 2026** AI-referred conversion and revenue per visit — the first clean read on whether the curve holds at volume
- **Stablecoin substitution** at sub-dollar ticket sizes, where card economics do not work at all

5 Instrument the agent flag now

Agent-originated transactions need to be identifiable in authorisation, fraud and dispute data **before** the volume arrives. Otherwise the first year of evidence is unreadable and every decision after it is a guess.

The technology question is largely settled. The open questions are liability, provisioning and distribution — and all three are ours to work.

Sources: American Express Agent Purchase Protection and ACE Developer Kit (14 Apr 2026) — first issuer liability commitment; Strivve on agent-selected card-on-file (17 Jul 2026); FIDO Alliance / Google AP2 and Mastercard Verifiable Intent (28 Apr 2026); PSD3/PSR trilogue status per Osborne Clarke and Reply (2026); NPCI Unified Agent Protocol pending RBI approval, per Business Standard (8 Jul 2026); Adobe Analytics for the holiday and quarterly conversion series; Coinbase x402 and Kansas City Fed on per-transaction economics.